

Honors

Top 5 (High Distinction) in the John Locke Economics Essay Competition	International	12
3x Gold Award (Top 8%): UKMT Senior Maths Challenge	International	10, 11, 12

CA See, Elisa CEEB: 686301 Fall 2024

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FY REA CAID: 36933440

1st Place, Best Policy Paper Presenter, Johor International Student Leadership Conference	State/Regional, National, International	11
Finalist (Top 5) in Malaysian Public Policy Competition: policy proposal on AI in job recruitment	National	12
1st Place, Best Speaker, Oxbridge-KTJ Debating Forum	State/Regional, National	11

Future plans

Policymaker/Government, Bachelors

Activities

Student Govt./Politics

10, 11, 12
Year
8 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr
Continue

Founder and Secretary General of International MUN, IntMUN increases Model United Nation access with free online conferences every summer & winter break
Bringing MUN to 3000 students; set up a Global MUN Network linking 20+ MUNs; helping students from Indonesia, Poland, Mexico, Yemen start MUN clubs

Research

11
School, Break
2 hr/wk, 5 wk/yr
Continue

Analysed the transparency of Malaysian charities , Wikilmpact: Foundations Report; analysing the transparency of 1500+ Malay foundations/charities
Collected data and conducted analysis on the level of disclosure from charities to highlight how current legislation requires reform as it is too lax

Journalism/Publication

11
School
27 hr/wk, 1 wk/yr
Continue

Social Media for Social Activism Programme, Fourth Media: Fourth Media Creators Camp (fully sponsored trip to another state for 3 days 2 nights)
1 of 12 selected students; produced news video on a refugee camp; reposted by Canadian High Commision; invited to mentor participants at the next camp

Internship

11, 12
Year
3 hr/wk, 12 wk/yr
Continue

Public Relations and Content Management Intern, YPolitics: NGO providing accessible resources to promote youth discourse around Malaysian politics
Content reached 12k Malaysians contributing to reform of AUKU, an act barring university students from participating in politics

Athletics: JV/Varsity

9, 10, 11, 12
School
5 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr
Continue

Field Hockey, 1st Team Captain Marlborough College Malaysia, Pushed for a longer hockey season in my school's sport program and more matches to raise its profile
Organised matches with state hockey team; coordinated fundraising sales to purchase 2 goals and hockey sticks for the local village school

Athletics: Club

9, 10
Year
15 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr
Continue

Figure Skating, Competitive Figure Skater, Co-Captain of BISR team, BISR team: 15 figure skaters who 'started late' competing nationally, regionally and internationally
1st place Skate Johor, Skate Malaysia and Skate Asia; Instagram(200k+ views) to motivate other "late" starters;Choreographed Malaysia Day performance

Community Service (Volunteer)

10, 11, 12
School
4 hr/wk, 28 wk/yr
Continue

Chairperson of the School's Charity Club, Raising and Giving Society: organising sustainable outreach events that go beyond just fundraising
College-wide charity Zombie Run, raising RM10,000 & fostering school spirit post-Covid; book donation drive to gift orphanage on World Book Day

Cultural

11, 12
School
5 hr/wk, 1 wk/yr
Continue

Began my Boarding House's Nations Day Tradition, Foodhall to celebrate diversity within my boarding house; every girl cooks/bakes a national dish
Frustrated that high-schoolers did not get to go for the school-wide foodhall, I organised a boarding house foodhall, becoming an annual tradition

Music: Instrumental

9, 10, 11, 12

Year

6 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr

Continue

Competitive Pianist , Representing Marlborough College Malaysia

Runner-up(2019, 2020) and Winner(2023) College Piano competition

AIMs Young Musician of the Year- finalist out of 60 contestants from across Malaysia

Social Justice

11

Break

8 hr/wk, 6 wk/yr

Continue

Volunteer IGCSE Chemistry Teacher for refugees, Alliance of Chin

Refugee Learning Centre; Secondary Learning Centre for refugees in Malaysia

Started a google classroom with chem resources for year-round use so students could access IGCSE materials whenever, not just if there were volunteers

Personal Statement

Mondays always suck. February 3, 2020 was no exception.

This time, Variety Magazine was to blame: *"Spinning Out" Cancelled After One Season at Netflix*.

Devastated, I turned to Instagram, sharing petitions decrying Netflix's decision, believing I could make a difference. As the number of signatures hit 80,000, I was certain Netflix would realise they had made a bad call.

Every morning, I refreshed Spinning Out's Instagram, anticipating an announcement the show was renewed.

It never came.

How could we gain so much traction, and still fail?

Clearly, social media activism was futile. My Instagram was now reserved for photodumps and cat memes.

Just as Kat's second chance at skating came when Dasha ambushed her, my second chance at social media activism came when collaborating with Undi18, a CSO targeting youth political participation. My original remit was researching prospective voter turnout prior to the Malaysian General Election; when tasked with initiating Instagram and TikTok campaigns encouraging Gen-Zs to vote, I was reluctant. Whilst my posts were celebrated for garnering over 100,000 views, I remained sceptical, still bitter virality failed to reunite me with Kat and Justin—it could not even get a show renewed, how could we naively believe it had a place in politics?

A chance encounter transformed my thinking. A girl with black-rimmed glasses approached me. Frantically, I pored through the memories of sports matches, music recitals, everything, desperate to avoid the uncomfortable "uhh... sorry, you are?"

I did not expect: "This is awkward, but are you the girl all over Undi18's TikTok?"

Lisa confessed she did not intend to vote, but reconsidered when she saw someone her age actively discussing the elections. This challenged my unfair opinion of social media activism. My false assumption social media was a substitute for political efforts was to blame, not social media activism. Spamming social media to "raise awareness" without actively working for change is pointless: logging on, writing an angry tweet, and continuing our mindless scroll is not an appropriate substitute. Unlike my failed Spinning Out campaign, my Undi18 posts worked because they did not highlight issues that we did nothing about; they made the public aware of Undi18's successful efforts to lower Malaysia's voting age to 18. Regardless of the likes they got, my posts alone would not have gotten Lisa to vote.

Unfortunately, just as I genuinely believed social media fame would save Spinning Out, many of my peers appear to be misguided, believing going viral instantaneously initiates actual change. Instead of using their knowledge to tackle the pressing challenges of radicalism and development, they complain on social media, poking fun at politicians. Whilst

acknowledging Malaysia's flaws is the necessary first step, we will never progress without real political reforms. The next step is proving that social media activism alone without concrete political efforts grounding it is meaningless. Growing up as the social media generation, we know how to weaponize social media to draw attention to pressing issues that must be addressed; the next step is equipping ourselves with the political acumen to begin solving them, so we can advance change. Showing my peers how to pave the path to progress ensures they do not end up dejected and disillusioned, as I was.

Thus, I founded International MUN, a beginner-friendly, free online Model United Nations conference that has reached 3,000 students globally. IntMUN works to prove the importance of politics in solving crises by simulating the UN, encouraging us to not simply condemn the politics of today, but instead devise innovative solutions to transnational problems. Recently, IntMUN has focused on building the Malaysian MUN community. Being awarded a \$3000 grant from the UN has supported me in my goal of facilitating MUN in under-resourced local schools and providing students the opportunity to lead their own self-sustaining MUN programs, and empowering the burgeoning youth-led political culture in Malaysia.

Mondays still suck. My new approach to social media activism, however, does not.

Supplemental Essays

Harvard has long recognized the importance of enrolling a diverse student body. How will the life experiences that shape who you are today enable you to contribute to Harvard?

Over summer, I researched the impact of NGOs, the UNHCR and Malaysia's government on refugee rights. I expected complex interdependence and positive-sum multilateralism to translate to the promotion of their rights; instead, the UNHCR feuded with the government over sovereignty, leaving under-resourced, local NGOs scrambling to provide stop-gap solutions for refugees.

This compelled me to initiate programmes that go beyond providing short-term relief, reducing refugee dependency on external support. Facilitating debating workshops at refugee Alternative Learning Centre, I saw myself in Dayan. She too had a name everyone mispronounced (it's Day-ann, not Diane). She too was the only girl in a sea of boys.

As our sessions progressed, so did she, slowly gaining the courage to dish out witty rebuttals that she once only dared whisper to me. Summer ended and I no longer saw my mini-me every Thursday. However, I found comfort knowing she now chairs her school's debate club and has recruited 2 more girls.

Through Harvard's Phillips Brooks House Association, I plan to empower refugees to spearhead their own sustainable progress through larger-scale capacity-building projects. Collaborating with BYRE would enable me to upscale my current efforts to increasing refugee access to debate to enhance leadership capabilities.

Briefly describe an intellectual experience that was important to you.

You are hopeless. All of you. I am an old woman, I cannot work, yet you refuse to help me.

Guilt gnawed at me as she stormed out. She sought help at her local politician's office but I could do nothing: existing welfare schemes left her unprotected.

Seeking moral justification, I consulted Hobbes' Leviathan, earning temporary relief. It suggested governments are not obligated to provide welfare, already protecting citizens from the 'state of nature'. However, Hobbes' proposition that legitimate governments must benefit citizens led me to Peter Singer, who asserts governments should provide welfare.

Economics could not rationalise the policy either. Whilst MIT's economics MOOC introduced me to Smith's 'invisible hand' and Okun's bucket, rendering government intervention inefficient, Cassidy's 'How Markets Fail' convinced me laissez-faire, free-market capitalism and pareto-efficiency are not synonymous to socially-desired outcomes, a thesis I expounded upon in my economics essay that placed top 5 in the John Locke Essay Competition.

Whilst these attempts at post-rationalisation failed to assuage my guilt, they showed me the value of interdisciplinary policy analysis. GOV94BD-Fighting Poverty will allow me to discuss

welfare policies through the lense of political economy, while GOV94BH-Ethics and Public Policy will remind me to consider moral implications.

Briefly describe any of your extracurricular activities, employment experience, travel, or family responsibilities that have shaped who you are.

Rest for three, come in on four. A simple beat that I proved unable to keep. Thoughts of embarrassing myself, when performing for the Queen, drowned out my inner metronome. I redrew my bow, ready to restart when the conductor declared practice over, telling me to stay behind. I guess this was the end of my first violin days, maybe even my time in the string quartet.

Instead, he reminded me performers were meant to provide something to the audience. Fixating on my fears was selfish: I was forcing the audience to indulge my self-doubt, not performing. When I focused on immersing them in our interpretation of Vivaldi's Spring, I no longer missed my cue.

This advice guided me at the Johor International Student Leadership Conference, where I proposed regulations on social media corporations to recalibrate perverse incentives amplifying populists. My sole goal 'Nas engaging my peers with Malaysian politics, and not even dropping my cue-cards could elicit self-conscious panic.

When awarding me Best Speaker, the judge commended me for arenoking thoughtful questions from the audience on curbing polarisation and populism.

How do you hope to use your Harvard education in the future?

Concerned relatives often warn me against studying in America, saying it will be "too different".

Yet, our two nations face similar challenges. Many people around the world are familiar with police brutality that faces people of colour in the US, but the inadequacies of Malaysia's justice system are often overlooked: our deeply-rooted, conservative Southeast-Asian values overly-emphasise retribution, and Malaysian-Indians disproportionately fall victim to police brutality.

Conducting research with YPolitics allowed me to investigate Malaysia's initial attempts to address reform our justice system, through the decriminalisation of suicide and the abolition of the mandatory death penalt,

Whilst I have initiated social media campaigns protesting our failing justice and prison systems, I do not know wha alternative policies I could propose to achieve real change that reconcile my objective of protecting human rights while respecting cultural relativism. Studying Gov 94BH: #AbolishPolice: the Politics of Public Safety in the Age of Social Media which explores the merits of police and prison abolition would support my investigation of police reform. I also hope to evaluate past effective activist tactics that could be applied to social media activism to reset Malaysian societal norms, emphasising the rehabilitative and reconciliatory functions of prison ivare age gusace syster.

Top 3 things your roommates might like to know about you.

1) Delulu is the solulu (delusion is the solution) is my life mantra, courtesy of TikTok: I will forever assert Harry Styles waved at me and no reality-check can change my mind. Sometimes, my confidence (read: delusion) lands me opportunities I would not otherwise access. My latest delusion involved adding the ex-Minister of Trade (whom I had never met) on LinkedIn and asking to assist with research. Clearly, delusion worked—I spent summer analysing Malaysia's economic policies.

2) Those labels are not typos, they are written in Malay. Kopi: coffee that keeps me awake after early morning gym. Coklat: your average chocolate... unless it has some durian chunks.

3) My room looks messy, but I promise everything coalesces into the perfect patchwork of everything Elisa. On the top shelf, there is the hockey ball I cracked during my first match as captain— it never fails to make me chuckle as I grab my shinpads and gumshield for practice. Below that is my ever-expanding collection of economics and politics books, with mismatched book-tabs peeking out of the pages. Please do not touch that haphazard pile of sheets on my desk! They are piano scores for the latest pieces I am learning, not undiscarded scrap.